

Context Will Beat Capability

PRAVAL SINGH | VP, Zoho



Praval Singh of Zoho takes the long view that only a home-grown software company can – from broadband to cloud to AI, with a fond memory of the Digit magazine CDs in between. His argument for the next 25 years is sharp: raw AI capability will matter less than AI that understands context, respects guardrails, and is built where the work actually happens.

How has tech evolved over the past 25 years, and role played by Digit in that journey?

Twenty-five years ago, owning a computer in India was still a statement. What followed was a series of cycles, each one faster than the last. The 2000s were about getting connected, broadband, desktops, early e-commerce. The 2010s shifted everything to mobile. Suddenly, the most important piece of technology most people owned fit in their pocket, and the entire software industry had to rebuild itself around that reality. Then came cloud computing, which moved the infrastructure conversation from hardware rooms to data centres, which people never had to think about earlier. Now, AI is doing something different from all of these, it is helping the tools evolve further and is changing what software can be expected to do.

Digit arrived when most people had more questions than answers about technology, and it became

the trusted place to go for answers. Through each of these waves, publications like Digit have helped readers keep pace as consumers and practitioners. I still remember getting a subscription during the early days, and waiting patiently for the next issue of not just the magazine, but also the complimentary CDs – loaded with free software – that used to come with it. :)

How is tech going to transform our lives in the next 25 years?

The transformation is already underway, and the next 25 years will largely be about where it reaches. AI will make it possible for people to accomplish a lot more, if applied to each business and individual's requirement aptly. That will reshape industries while also creating new ones like never before, I think.

What I think will matter most is not the raw capability of AI but how contextually it works. AI that understands the business, workflows, and the customers it serves will deliver far more value than AI dropped onto generic infrastructure. Equally important would be AI that respects guardrails and handles data with a privacy-first approach. The companies and platforms that understand this distinction, will define the next 25 years.

For India, this is also a moment to build on our own terms. With data sovereignty, homegrown infrastructure, and deep domain understanding becoming differentiators, India is better placed than ever to not just adopt technology but help shape it. Add to that, the talent the country has and there is no reason why we should be sitting on the sidelines of that conversation.

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Any message to Digit on completing 25 years?

Digit has been part of the backdrop of Indian tech for the past two decades. The work that Digit has done in testing, reviewing, and explaining technology honestly and objectively will have lasting impact on how consumers approach technology. Congratulations on 25 years to everyone at Team Digit. The next chapter already looks like a good one. 